

Purple Coneflower

Echinacea purpurea

Eastern Purple Coneflower



QUALITIES

A clumping prairie composite 2 to 3 feet tall, with rough hairy lance-shaped leaves and large daisy-like flowers from July through September. The drooping rose-pink ray petals surround a spiny copper-orange central cone made of hundreds of tiny disc florets. Cones persist into winter as architectural seedheads favored by goldfinches.

CARE

Full sun, average to dry well-drained soil. Tolerates clay better than most coneflowers. Hardy to USDA Zone 3. Plant from 1-gallon container or seed in fall; self-seeds modestly into receptive areas (a feature in naturalistic plantings). Deadheading extends bloom but removes the seed source for goldfinches; consider leaving half. Cut stems to 6 inches in late winter.

HISTORY

Echinacea derives from Greek *echinos*, "hedgehog" — for the spiny central cone. Plains tribes used the root extensively as an immune-system modulator, applying it for everything from snakebite to toothache to colds. European settlers adopted the use, and a 19th-century Nebraska physician's commercial Echinacea preparations became one of the most widely-sold patent medicines of the era. Modern research has confirmed several of the traditional uses; Echinacea remains a top-selling herbal supplement worldwide.

REASON TO BE

Purple coneflower is the public face of native-plant gardening: instantly recognizable, beloved by visitors, tolerant of mistakes, and ecologically generous. Long-tongued bees and butterflies (especially Monarchs, Fritillaries, and Painted Ladies) work the cones; goldfinches and other small finches harvest the seeds through fall and winter. In a residential design it carries the show from July through September while neighboring forbs hand off bloom.